

Does social interaction equal the sum of contributions of interacting people, or is there something additional to it?

The text below addresses this question. The text consists of direct quotations from

De Jaegher, H., & Di Paolo, E. (2007). Participatory sense-making: An enactive approach to social cognition. Phenomenology and the cognitive sciences, 6(4), 485-507.

...[W]e take *coordination* to mean the non-accidental correlation between the behaviours of two or more systems that are in sustained coupling, or have been coupled in the past, or have been coupled to another, common, system.

A correlation [the term 'correlation' as used in this paper is different from statistical analyses; it stands for the presence of similarities in a more qualitative way – Aliaksandr] is a coherence in the behaviour of two or more systems over and above what is expected, given what those systems are capable of doing.

For instance, when we observe a crowd of people walking on a busy road, the fact that they walk is not surprising, and we do not label this a case of coordination since walking is one of the things people do on a road (as opposed to, say, flying). But if we find that they are all walking in the same direction this could be a correlation, and if we suspect that this is not by accident, we can hypothesise the presence of a coordinating factor (for instance, an anti-war demonstration).

The concept of coordination helps us to understand the social interaction as an ongoing process. We must go beyond a view that defines interaction as simply the spatio-temporal coincidence of two agents that influence each other. We must move towards an understanding of how their history of coordination demarcates the interaction as an identifiable pattern with its own internal structure, and its own role to play in the process of understanding each other and the world.

Something that is not so common in cases of purely physical coupling, but that we find in the social domain, is that patterns of coordination can directly influence the continuing disposition [= *inclinations, tendencies* – Aliaksandr] of the individuals involved to sustain or modify their encounter. In this way, what arises in the process of coordination (e.g. gestures, utterances and changes in intonation that are sometimes labelled as back-channeling or turn-repair, etc.) can have the consequence of steering the encounter or facilitating (or not) its

continuation. And the particular unravelling of these dynamics itself influences what kinds of coordination are more likely to happen. This is due to the fact that the interactors are highly plastic systems that are susceptible to being affected by the history of coordination.

Even though normal social encounters, for instance conversations, may only last a few minutes, our point is that during that period they may organize themselves according to the two avenues of influence just described: the agents sustain the encounter, and the encounter itself influences the agents and invests them with the role of interactors. The interaction process emerges as an entity when social encounters acquire this operationally closed organization. It constitutes a level of analysis not reducible, in general, to individual behaviours.

At the same time, it is vital to avoid the error of considering only the interaction and ignoring the individual elements in it. Hence our emphasis on the autonomy of the interactors throughout their engagement with each other in order for the interaction to be considered properly social. For example, couple dancing involves moving each other, making each other move, and being moved by each other. This goes for both leader and follower. Following is part of an agreement and does not equate with being shifted into position by the other. If the follower were to give up her autonomy, the couple dancing would end there, and it would look more like a doll being carried around the dance floor. The same goes for conversations: each partner must engage from an autonomous standpoint. If conversational autonomy were given up, neither partner would be able to influence the other.

To illustrate participatory sense-making [*of the world, interaction, etc.* – Aliaksandr], we must drastically reduce the complexity of the situation. Consider the game of charades. This is a game of pantomimes: players have to ‘act out’ a phrase without speaking, while the other members of the same team try to guess what the phrase is. Imagine that the phrase is the title of a film with two words. There are well-established gestures for indicating this (e.g., emulating an old camera by rotating the right hand in small circles in front of the eye, and indicating the number two by tapping the arm with two fingers). These gestures are readily interpreted. The player starts miming the second word. With his fingers he draws a large square in the air in front of him. Someone suggests “box”. He gestures “no”. Another guesses “picture”, again no. He changes the gesture, drawing the big square again and then moving his hands together to the centre of the square and pulling his closed hands towards him while opening his arms outwards. “Cupboard.” “Wardrobe.” He gestures “no” but adds a waving ‘almost there’ movement of the hand. Then he makes the same square, puts his hands in the middle, but now pushes his hands forwards and outwards with an opening movement and then leans forwards with his upper body and moves his head and gaze from left to right. The right answer comes: “Window!” Then he points to his back with his thumb over his shoulder. “Rear Window!” This situation begins very much like the examples of orientation. The player intends to orient his team-mates. In the beginning this is easy thanks to established conventions. The first attempt at gesturing a window is misinterpreted. The player now must improve the situation by adding to the initial gesture something more specific, so he gestures the opening of a window. The team-mates do not yet guess the right answer, but their guesses

show that they have understood the ‘opening’ aspect. Now the player can improve on this partial re-affirmation of his intended meaning and he gestures the act of opening the window again, but this time outwards (avoiding previous misinterpretations); he stresses the gesture by looking out. Now they guess correctly. As the interaction unfolds, what started off as orientation becomes more symmetrical since all interactors have to adjust their sense-making in a way that converges towards the ‘right’ gesture and the ‘right’ interpretation. **The new meaning of the gesture is jointly constructed during interaction and evolves through patterns of coordination and breakdowns. It is now available to the interactors for further use and possible transformation** *[highlighted by Aliaksandr]*.